

ECHELONS OF POWER
(from right) Pakistan's Field Marshal Asim Munir, Saudi Arabia's Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman, Pakistan PM Shehbaz Sharif and Saudi Defence Minister Khalid bin Salman in Riyadh, Sept. 17, 2025

PAK-LED EFFORT, WITH SUPPORT FROM CHINA, BORE SOME LAST-MINUTE RESULTS. BUT PEACE IS MORE COMPLEX THAN WAR. EACH SIDE SEEKS TO PRESERVE ITS POSITION, MAKING NEGOTIATIONS DIFFICULT

maintain stability as we await the outcome of the two-week ceasefire that has been announced. This approach has also helped keep casualties relatively low across the Gulf.

THE FUTURE TRAJECTORY

Looking ahead, there are concerns about investor confidence and the "safe harbour" image of the Gulf. But history suggests resilience. Kuwait was invaded in 1991; today, it is fully reintegrated into global economic life. Crises do not define countries—responses do. What is visible now is strong cooperation among Gulf states. Saudi Arabia has opened its infrastructure to neighbours, facilitated logistics and supported stranded residents. There is a sense that the GCC (Gulf Cooperation Council) is acting as a cooperative bloc, not a competitive one. That unity will be key to recovery.

Another question that arises is regional balance. If Iran is weakened, does Israel emerge as the dominant power, and is Saudi Arabia comfortable with that? The answer is pragmatic. Israel is already a strong military power. But it has never fired missiles or drones at Saudi Arabia. Iran has, and consistently over decades. At present, Iran is seen as the more immediate threat. At the same time, Saudi Arabia's long-term vision is not built on confrontation. The idea of an integrated, peaceful region—including both Iran and Israel—remains. But that vision requires conditions: Iran must stop destabilising activities, and Israel must address the Palestinian question. There is no ideological opposition to coexistence, only practical conditions.

On mediation, efforts led by Pakistan, with support from China, have shown some last-minute results. But peace is inherently more complex than war. Each side seeks to preserve its position, making negotiations difficult. Still, the stakes are global. Ending the war is not just a regional priority, it is an international one.

For expatriates, including nearly 3 million Indians in Saudi Arabia, life remains largely normal. Governments across the Gulf have emphasised equal protection for citizens and residents. Repatriation options have been provided, but day-to-day life continues with minimal disruption. Finally, on worst-case scenarios—such as attacks on critical infrastructure like desalination plants—Saudi Arabia's message is one of preparedness. Multiple contingencies are in place, and the armed forces remain on high alert. Restraint should not be mistaken for weakness. Saudi Arabia has the capability to respond if required. But for now, the strategy is deliberate: avoid escalation, stabilise markets, and push for a diplomatic resolution. War, after all, is easy to start. Peace is much harder to achieve. ■